BATTLE OF THE FISHES

A community-driven project in Solapur and Pune, Maharashtra, aims to rid the Ujani dam catchment areas of invasive fish species and reintroduce native varieties

By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni** *in Bhigwan and Solapur*

In **a first-of-its-kind community-driven project, fishermen in Maharashtra's Ujani dam area in Solapur and Pune are being enlisted** in a battle between good and evil—when it comes to fish. Once home to native species such as Maral (Channa marulius), Gugali (Pachypterus sp) and Tambrya (Labeo fimbriatus), the waters of Ujani—the largest dam in Maharashtra by storage capacity—are now infested with invasive species such as suckermouth (Pterygoplichthys sp), tilapia (Oreochromis sp) and Thai Mangur (Clarias gariepinus).

For the 150,000-odd fishermen who depend on Ujani and the larger ecosystem around it in Pune, Solapur and Ahilyanagar districts, this has meant losing the premium that native fish command at the wholesale freshwater fish markets such as Bhigwan in Pune. Maral, for instance, which is in demand even outside Maharashtra, sells for Rs 500-600 a kg, compared with Rs 30-100 a kg for tilapia (depending on size). Aher can command as much as Rs 2,000-2,500 a kg for its taste and reputed medicinal properties, says Mauli Nagare, a fish wholesaler at Bhigwan. "Local varieties of fish have become so rare that when a good catch comes in, there is a rush to buy it," says fisherman Rahul Bhoi. Every year, around 3,500 tonnes of fish caught in Ujani are sold in markets across Solapur and Pune districts.

Together, tilapia, suckermouth and Mangur have driven out native fish varieties and now account for some 97 per cent of the catch from the Ujani reservoir, says Unmesh Katwate, senior scientist and assistant director at the Bombay Natural History Society (BNHS). Not only are these alien species prolific breeders, they are also highly destructive. The suckermouth, native to the Amazon in South America, is an aquarium fish that found its way into freshwater bodies and eventually Ujani. Locally known as the 'helicopter fish' or *yeda maasa* (mad fish), it feeds on the eggs of local fish and even damages riverbanks with its constant burrowing. Tilapia, on the other hand, was commercially cage-farmed in the 1990s and escaped into the wild. Also called 'jalebi' fish, it has two distinct sources of origin—the Nile and Mozambique. The Thai Mangur, or African catfish, preys on native fish and even migratory birds in Ujani. Despite health concerns over its consumption, illegal breeding farms have proliferated

FOREIGN INVADERS



SUCKERMOUTH CATFISH
Originally a South American aquarium fish, the bottom feeder is now a menace
PRICE ₹35-38 per kg



AFRICAN CATFISH OR THAI MANGUR
An air-breathing fish, the Centre banned it in 2019, but illegal Mangur farming is still on
PRICE ₹80 per kg



TILAPIA
An aquaculture species, the 'Ujani pomfret' is a prolific breeder. It has thinned out local fish populations
PRICE ₹100 per kg



MANDAR DEODHAR